without oddness myself, as people would always be quick to tell me. But I trusted these guys' instincts. My endless travels across the Australian landscape – and education system – made me something of a social outsider, but in Trax I found a kindred spirit. Like me, he came from a poor but intellectual family. Both of his parents were recent immigrants to Australia, still retaining the German accents that had embarrassed Trax as a child. Prime Suspect, on the other hand, came from an upper-middle-class background and on the surface was a studious grammar-school boy bound for university. But Prime Suspect was a damaged young man. The only thing that had saved his parents from an acrimonious divorce battle was his father's death from cancer when Prime Suspect was eight. Widowed and stuck with two young children, his mother had retreated into bitterness and anger. And Prime Suspect in turn had retreated into his bedroom and into his computer.

We were all misfits in our different ways, but our differences equalised in the strange impersonal universe of the hacker. Under our own and each other's tutelage, we had graduated from being funsters to being cryptographers. And in company with a whole international subculture, we had become aware of how cryptography could lead to political change. We were cypherpunks. The movement started around 1992 and was held together by a mailing list, a meeting point for our discussions of computer science, politics, philosophy and mathematics. There were never more than about 1,000 subscribers, but those people laid the foundations of where cryptography was going: they showed the way for all the modern battles over privacy.

We were engaged in establishing a system for the new information age, the Internet age, that would allow individuals, rather than merely corporations, to protect their privacy. We could write code and would use that ability to give people jurisdiction over their rights. The whole movement tapped into a part of my mind, or you could say my soul: I realised through the cypherpunk movement that justice in the future might depend on us working for a balance, via the Internet, of what corporations consider secrets and what individuals consider private. As it used to stand, before we seized the tools, privacy was only a matter of advantage for corporations, banks and governments: but we saw a new frontline, in which people's power could be enhanced with information.